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# 1928, Ferozeshah Kotla

On a cold dank night on 8 September 1928, under cover of darkness, some townsfolk, having wrapped themselves in finely woven homespun woollen shawls, gathered around the ramparts of an old medieval fort, in earnest, to listen to the evening's classical musical performance. A sarangi twanged in the distance as its custodian applied the bow to the metal wires, its piercing sound echoing in the still of the night. A tabla player tendentiously checked the tone of his tabla, readying himself to spring into action. The singer cleared his throat and opened with a *bada* khayal in an evening raga in Yaman Kalyan. Unbeknownst to them, a tall young man dressed in *khaddar* in a lungi stretching down to his ankles, but with chiselled good looks, had also stolen in amid the haunting red sandstone ruins of the Qutub complex. Over two days, he would welcome other young men and preside over a meeting of various insurgent groups that had sprung up in India in the early 1920s. Delhi in those days lacked auditoriums. This is where the fort of Ferozeshah Kotla, with its awe-inspiring architectural ruins, provided a perfect backdrop for gatherings and assemblies of disaffected youth who could meet in secret, away from the prying eyes of the security services. Here they found just the safety and seclusion that they craved to hatch their seditious plans.

For all these reasons, the significance of the meeting at the fort of Ferozeshah Kotla ought not to be lost on independent India. A single lonely plaque is displayed today on the site. It does not do it justice, and nor does the fact that it remains off the beaten track, hardly visited today by anyone. By calling that meeting, what Bhagat Singh had managed to do was to unify the various revolutionary groups from different parts of the country. These